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Democracy Dies in Darkness

TUESDAY, FEBRUARY 24, 2026 • \$4

State of the Union gives Trump a chance to reset

In a hardened political landscape, the speech's impact could be limited

BY CAT ZAKRZEWSKI
AND EMILY DAVIES

President Donald Trump will deliver his State of the Union address to Congress on Tuesday night at one of the most fragile moments of his second term, as he confronts new Supreme Court limits on his agenda, voter anger over inflation and growing cracks within his MAGA coalition ahead of the midterms.

But in an age of hardened political divides, shrinking attention spans and declining television viewership, it's unlikely that even one of Washington's most enduring political traditions can reset the course of his embattled ad-

ministration, according to interviews with Republican political consultants, historians and communications experts.

The State of the Union remains one of the rare moments when Trump is guaranteed airtime across networks to speak directly to a nationwide audience, and the constitutionally mandated address to the legislative branch remains a powerful symbol of the separation of powers. But in the age of algorithm-driven social media feeds and bite-size video clips, the audience for the speech is increasingly fragmented and entrenched in their political positions.

The carefully crafted speeches

SEE TRUMP ON A2

Live updates

The Post's coverage of President Donald Trump's State of the Union address begins at 8:30 p.m. at [washingtonpost.com](https://www.washingtonpost.com).

Trump gets legal victory on classified documents

Release of report on how materials were handled after first term is blocked

BY PERRY STEIN

A federal judge in Florida blocked public release of special counsel Jack Smith's extensive report on the classified-documents case against President Donald Trump — a resounding victory for Trump's efforts to block public viewing of what probably would be damaging details about his retention of classi-

fied materials after he left the White House in 2021.

The decision Monday morning from U.S. District Judge Aileen M. Cannon resulted from litigation that has dragged on for more than a year in her courtroom. Cannon ruled that releasing the special counsel report could violate grand jury secrecy rules and could result in impugning the presumption of innocence for Trump and his co-defendants in a case that did not result in guilty verdicts.

The ruling can be appealed. Although Trump and the Justice Department both opposed the public release of the report, First

SEE REPORT ON A9

Top general sees risk in attack on Iran



STELIOS MISINIS/REUTERS

The aircraft carrier USS Gerald R. Ford arrived at Souda Bay on the island of Crete on Monday.

CAINE EXPRESSES CONCERNS TO TRUMP

Munitions shortfalls, wavering allies cited

BY JOHN HUDSON
AND TARA COPP

As the Trump administration weighs an attack on Iran, the Pentagon's top general has cautioned President Donald Trump and other officials that shortfalls in critical munitions and a lack of support from allies will add significant risk to the operation and to U.S. personnel, according to people familiar with internal discussions.

Gen. Dan Caine, chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, expressed his concerns at a White House meeting last week with Trump and his top aides, these people said, cautioning that any major operation against Iran will face challenges because the U.S. munitions stockpile has been significantly depleted by Washington's ongoing defense of Israel and support for Ukraine. Caine's remarks at the White House meeting have not been previously reported.

Separately, in Pentagon meetings this month, Caine also has raised concerns about the scale of any Iran campaign, its inherent complexity and the possibility of U.S. casualties, one person said. The general has said that any operation would be made all the more difficult by a lack of allied support, this person said, speaking like others on the condition of anonymity to discuss private conversations.

In a statement, Caine's office said that in his role as the president's top military adviser, the chairman "provides a range of military options, as well as sec-

SEE IRAN ON A13

Prep for war: Israelis brace for fallout of potential U.S. strike. **A12**

Is autism preventable in some cases after all?

Some research suggests environmental factors early may influence risk

BY ARIANA EUNJUNG CHA

Obstetrician Jeanne Conry has long paid attention to the "1,300-day window"—the months before conception through a child's second birthday. Studies show nutrition and lifestyle during this period can shape pregnancy outcomes and the long-term health of the babies. Conry began to wonder if such factors could also influence autism.

She is now helping lead an educational push aimed at alerting women to their exposure to toxins, stress and infections during this narrow and consequential window — guided by the idea that what happens then may subtly shape eggs or sperm, and in turn, influence a child's development long before pregnancy begins.

"The more we research, the more we see links between different chemical exposures and autism so if we reduce those links we will ideally reduce cases," Conry said.

For years, movements like this existed on the fringes. But recent studies are giving it new weight, raising a provocative question that was once almost taboo: could

SEE AUTISM ON A5

Redistricting plan is all but dead, but Gov. Moore still pushing

BY ERIN COX

While Maryland Gov. Wes Moore (D) spent last week in verbal combat with President Donald Trump over a sewage spill, he was also quietly losing his biggest political battle at home.

Moore's months-long fight to redraw Maryland's congressional maps — and oust its lone Republican member of Congress — produced zero movement among

Md. Senate Democrats have resisted effort to redraw electoral map

Democrats in the Maryland Senate.

Despite a public pressure campaign without modern precedent in this deep-blue state, which

typically resolves intraparty fights behind closed doors, Tuesday's unofficial deadline to act on mid-cycle redistricting ahead of the 2026 midterms will come and go without fellow Democrats heeding Moore's demands for a vote.

"The window of opportunity is closed for '26," said Maryland Senate President Bill Ferguson (D-Baltimore City), who refuses to redistrict, arguing that the

state's Democrats have already gerrymandered as much as possible and that further attempts will backfire.

The apparent loss, which Moore vehemently does not concede, draws a sharp contrast between himself and another potential 2028 Democratic presidential contender, California Gov. Gavin Newsom (D), who swiftly persuaded his state's legislators and voters to redraw five more Demo-

cratic-leaning seats in retaliation for Republican gerrymandering done at Trump's behest in Texas.

Other potential 2028 presidential candidates also did not push through redistricting, but Moore stands alone as a Democrat who vowed to fight Trump with a redistricting scheme but failed to

SEE MOORE ON A6

Chasing a majority: House Dems target districts won by Trump. **A6**



DREW CALLISTER/AP

Digging out

Christa Prince shovels snow in her New York neighborhood on Monday. A powerful storm rocked the Mid-Atlantic and Northeast, dumping up to 24 inches of snow in some locations. **Story, A8.**

Andrew's spiral caused royal generational divide

Queen Elizabeth held out hope for her wayward son; Charles and William fumed over his misconduct

BY KARLA ADAM

LONDON — As sordid allegations engulfed Prince Andrew, the middle of her three sons, Queen Elizabeth displayed the eternal hope of a mother. Charles, heir to the throne, showed the cold impatience of a sibling. And William, the embarrassed dismay of a nephew.

Countless families deal with a difficult relative. In the House of Windsor, he was the not-so-grand Duke of York — now reduced to Andrew Mountbatten-Windsor after being stripped of his royal titles over his ties to convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein.

Andrew has long been a thorn in the royal family's side as he denied allegations of sexual misconduct, and yet again and again

new evidence revealed his ties to Epstein were far closer and went on far longer than he admitted.

But the three generations of the royal family each confronted the challenge differently, reflecting their own personal stake in Andrew's downward spiral.

Last week, after Mountbatten-Windsor was arrested in connection with potential misconduct during his time as a trade envoy, King Charles III issued a terse, first-person statement — extremely rare for a British monarch. "Let me state clearly: the law must take its course," Charles said.

It was a clear move to place institutional distance between the monarch and his beleaguered brother who, if charged with a

SEE ROYALS ON A14

IN THE NEWS

"Angel Family Day" On the eve of his State of the Union address, President Donald Trump uses a White House ceremony to try to reframe the debate on illegal immigration. **A4**

Biden health update Former president Joe Biden, who is being treated for prostate cancer, is said to be doing well by aides. **A7**

THE NATION

The Supreme Court will consider if states can sue over greenhouse gas emissions. **A4**
Nick Reiner pleaded not guilty to murder charges in the deaths of his parents last year. **A4**

THE WORLD

Mexico is braced for more violence after the military killed the crime boss "El Mencho" **A11**
Peter Mandelson, the ex-U.K. ambassador to the U.S., is arrested amid Epstein fallout. **A14**

STYLE

Audio erotica's golden era is upon us, some say, with more of it available in better quality than ever before, with TV shows "Heated Rivalry as an example. **B1**
Vandalism forced the Kennedy Center to cancel a touring skating company's show. **B1**

SPORTS

A Ukrainian teen forced to flee her country because of war is now a New York high school tennis champion with even bigger dreams. **C7**
Michael Jordan is leading the way as upstart teams sit atop early NASCAR standings. **C7**

THE REGION

The state of Maryland sued the Trump Administration to stop plans for an immigration detention center in Washington County. **C11**
Fairfax County authorities say a man killed his wife and daughter before an officer killed him. **C11**

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